PROJECTIVE SCHEMES ADMIT NON-EFFECTIVE ETALE DESCENT DATA

THE STACKS PROJECT AUTHORS

Editorial note. The earlier non-locality-of-projectivity example is retained as uncounted proof support. This task counts the stronger non-effectivity of a projective descent datum, not the earlier example as a second task.

Allowed standard prerequisites (editorial).

- Explicit prerequisite boundary. Blowups of smooth centres and their strict transforms, finite-group torsors and invariant quotients, affine descent, regular-local factoriality, rational equivalence and degree of line bundles on proper cycles.

Source reference. Original definition 080D: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 10178–10178. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Source reference. Original lemma 02NS: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 3491–3491. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Source reference. Original lemma 02S2: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 3645–3645. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Source reference. Original lemma 02TI: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 3697–3697. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Source reference. Original definition 049A: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 5573–5573. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Source reference. Original lemma 0245: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 2766–2766. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Date: stacks-project:examples.tex:local-snapshot-20261011; GNU FDL 1.2 or later.

Source reference. Original lemma 0AG0: focused-seeds/AGP/sources/stacks-snapshot-20261011/tags.txt, source lines 13178–13178. Stable Stacks tag for an expressly allowed foundational or notational input; the counted construction remains the two concrete core obligations. The retained local core is not replaced by this pointer. See standard_prerequisites.

Lemma 0.1. *There is an etale covering $X \to S$ of schemes and a descent datum $(V/X, \varphi)$ relative to $X \to S$ such that $V \to X$ is projective, but the descent datum is not effective in the category of schemes.*

Lemma 0.2. *The properties*

$\mathcal{P}(f) =$ "*f is projective*", *and*
$\mathcal{P}(f) =$ "*f is quasi-projective*"

are not Zariski local on the base. A fortiori, they are not fpqc local on the base.

Proof. Following Hironaka [1, Example B.3.4.1], we define a proper morphism of smooth complex 3-folds $f : V_Y \to Y$ which is Zariski-locally projective, but not projective. Since f is proper and not projective, it is also not quasi-projective.

Let Y be projective 3-space over the complex numbers $\mathbf{C}$. Let C and D be smooth conics in Y such that the closed subscheme $C \cap D$ is reduced and consists of two complex points P and Q. (For example, let $C = \{[x, y, z, w] : xy = z^2, w = 0\}$, $D = \{[x, y, z, w] : xy = w^2, z = 0\}$, $P = [1, 0, 0, 0]$, and $Q = [0, 1, 0, 0]$.) On $Y - Q$, first blow up the curve C, and then blow up the strict transform of the curve D (Divisors, Definition 080D). On $Y - P$, first blow up the curve D, and then blow up the strict transform of the curve C. Over $Y - P - Q$, the two varieties we have constructed are canonically isomorphic, and so we can glue them over $Y - P - Q$. The result is a smooth proper 3-fold V_Y over $\mathbf{C}$. The morphism $f : V_Y \to Y$ is proper and Zariski-locally projective (since it is a blowup over $Y - P$ and over $Y - Q$), by Divisors, Lemma 02NS. We will show that V_Y is not projective over $\mathbf{C}$. That will imply that f is not projective.

To do this, let L be the inverse image in V_Y of a complex point of $C - P - Q$, and M the inverse image of a complex point of $D - P - Q$. Then L and M are isomorphic to the projective line $\mathbf{P}^1_{\mathbf{C}}$. Next, let E be the inverse image in V_Y of $C \cup D \subset Y$ in V_Y; thus $E \to C \cup D$ is a proper morphism, with fibers isomorphic to $\mathbf{P}^1$ over $(C \cup D) - \{P, Q\}$. The inverse image of P in E is a union of two lines L_0 and M_0, and we have rational equivalences of cycles $L \sim L_0 + M_0$ and $M \sim M_0$ on E (using that C and D are isomorphic to $\mathbf{P}^1$). Note the asymmetry resulting from the order in which we blew up the two curves. Near Q, the opposite happens. So the inverse image of Q is the union of two lines L'_0 and M'_0, and we have rational equivalences $L \sim L'_0$ and $M \sim L'_0 + M'_0$ on E. Combining these equivalences, we find that $L_0 + M'_0 \sim 0$ on E and hence on V_Y. If V_Y were projective over $\mathbf{C}$, it would have an ample line bundle H, which would have degree > 0 on all curves in V_Y. In particular H would have positive degree on $L_0 + M'_0$, contradicting that the degree of a line bundle is well-defined on 1-cycles modulo rational equivalence on a proper scheme over a field (Chow Homology, Lemma 02S2 and Lemma 02TI). So V_Y is not projective over $\mathbf{C}$. □

Proof. We imitate Hironaka's example of a smooth separated complex algebraic space of dimension 3 which is not a scheme [1, Example B.3.4.2].

Consider the action of the group $G = \mathbf{Z}/2 = \{1, g\}$ on projective 3-space $\mathbf{P}^3$ over the complex numbers by

$$g[x, y, z, w] = [y, x, w, z].$$

The action is free outside the two disjoint lines $L_1 = \{[x, x, z, z]\}$ and $L_2 = \{[x, -x, z, -z]\}$ in $\mathbf{P}^3$. Let $Y = \mathbf{P}^3 - (L_1 \cup L_2)$. There is a smooth quasi-projective scheme $S = Y/G$ over $\mathbf{C}$ such that $Y \to S$ is a G-torsor (Groupoids, Definition 049A). Explicitly, we can define S as the image of the open subset Y in $\mathbf{P}^3$ under the morphism

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{P}^3 &\to \text{Proj } \mathbf{C}[x, y, z, w]^G \\ &= \text{Proj } \mathbf{C}[u_0, u_1, v_0, v_1, v_2]/(v_0 v_1 = v_2^2),\end{aligned}$$

where $u_0 = x+y$, $u_1 = z+w$, $v_0 = (x-y)^2$, $v_1 = (z-w)^2$, and $v_2 = (x-y)(z-w)$, and the ring is graded with u_0, u_1 in degree 1 and v_0, v_1, v_2 in degree 2.

Let $C = \{[x, y, z, w] : xy = z^2, w = 0\}$ and $D = \{[x, y, z, w] : xy = w^2, z = 0\}$. These are smooth conic curves in $\mathbf{P}^3$, contained in the G-invariant open subset Y, with $g(C) = D$. Also, $C \cap D$ consists of the two points $P := [1, 0, 0, 0]$ and $Q := [0, 1, 0, 0]$, and these two points are switched by the action of G.

Let $V_Y \to Y$ be the scheme which over $Y - P$ is defined by blowing up D and then the strict transform of C, and over $Y - Q$ is defined by blowing up C and then the strict transform of D. (This is the same construction as in the proof of Lemma 0.2, except that Y here denotes an open subset of $\mathbf{P}^3$ rather than all of $\mathbf{P}^3$.) Then the action of G on Y lifts to an action of G on V_Y, which switches the inverse images of $Y - P$ and $Y - Q$. This action of G on V_Y gives a descent datum $(V_Y/Y, \varphi_Y)$ on V_Y relative to the G-torsor $Y \to S$. The morphism $V_Y \to Y$ is proper but not projective, as shown in the proof of Lemma 0.2.

Let X be the disjoint union of the open subsets $Y - P$ and $Y - Q$; then we have surjective etale morphisms $X \to Y \to S$. Let V be the pullback of $V_Y \to Y$ to X; then the morphism $V \to X$ is projective, since $V_Y \to Y$ is a blowup over each of the open subsets $Y - P$ and $Y - Q$. Moreover, the descent datum $(V_Y/Y, \varphi_Y)$ pulls back to a descent datum $(V/X, \varphi)$ relative to the etale covering $X \to S$.

Suppose that this descent datum is effective in the category of schemes. That is, there is a scheme $U \to S$ which pulls back to the morphism $V \to X$ together with its descent datum. Then U would be the quotient of V_Y by its G-action.

$$\begin{array}{ccc} V & \longrightarrow & X \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ V_Y & \longrightarrow & Y \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ U & \longrightarrow & S \end{array}$$

Let E be the inverse image of $C \cup D \subset Y$ in V_Y; thus $E \to C \cup D$ is a proper morphism, with fibers isomorphic to $\mathbf{P}^1$ over $(C \cup D) - \{P, Q\}$. The inverse image of P in E is a union of two lines L_0 and M_0. It follows that the inverse image of $Q = g(P)$ in E is the union of two lines $L_0' = g(M_0)$ and $M_0' = g(L_0)$. As shown in the proof of Lemma 0.2, we have a rational equivalence $L_0 + M_0' = L_0 + g(L_0) \sim 0$ on E.

By descent of closed subschemes, there is a curve $L_1 \subset U$ (isomorphic to $\mathbf{P}^1$) whose inverse image in V_Y is $L_0 \cup g(L_0)$. (Use Descent, Lemma 0245, noting that a closed immersion is an affine morphism.) Let R be a complex point of L_1. Since we assumed that U is a scheme, we can choose a function f in the local ring $O_{U,R}$ that vanishes at R but not on the whole curve L_1. Let D_{loc} be an irreducible component of the closed subset $\{f = 0\}$ in $\operatorname{Spec} O_{U,R}$; then D_{loc} has codimension

1. The closure of D_{loc} in U is an irreducible divisor D_U in U which contains the point R but not the whole curve L_1. The inverse image of D_U in V_Y is an effective divisor D which intersects $L_0 \cup g(L_0)$ but does not contain either curve L_0 or $g(L_0)$.

Since the complex 3-fold V_Y is smooth, $O(D)$ is a line bundle on V_Y. We use here that a regular local ring is factorial, or in other words is a UFD, see More on Algebra, Lemma 0AG0. The restriction of $O(D)$ to the proper surface $E \subset V_Y$ is a line bundle which has positive degree on the 1-cycle $L_0 + g(L_0)$, by our information on D. Since $L_0 + g(L_0) \sim 0$ on E, this contradicts that the degree of a line bundle is well-defined on 1-cycles modulo rational equivalence on a proper scheme over a field (Chow Homology, Lemma 02S2 and Lemma 02TI). Therefore the descent datum $(V/X, \varphi)$ is in fact not effective; that is, U does not exist as a scheme. □

References

[1] Robin Hartshorne. *Algebraic Geometry*, volume 52 of *Graduate Texts in Mathematics*. Springer-Verlag, 1977.